

English uses different constructions to talk about the future. These are mostly formed with the auxiliary verb "will" or a form of "be" with "going to."

See also:

The future with "going to" 17

The future with "will" 18

The **future perfect** is used to predict when an action or event will be finished. This tense looks back from an imagined time in the future.

They **will have** built the skyscraper by next year.

The **future perfect continuous** is used to predict the eventual duration of an activity. This tense looks back from the endpoint of the action.

By July, they **will have been working** on it for a year.



The **future in the past** describes thoughts about the future that someone had at some point in the past. There are three ways to form this construction.

The traffic was terrible, so I knew I **was going to** be late.

"Am going to" becomes
"was going to."

"Will" becomes
"would."

I thought I **would** finish the gardening by the end of the day.

I was nervous on Sunday night. I **was starting** a new job the next day.

"Am starting" becomes
"was starting."

"**Will**" is used when a decision is made at the time of speaking.

I know! I'll **buy** Jo a surfboard for her birthday.

This decision was not planned in advance.



"**Going to**" is used when talking about a decision that has already been made.

I'm **going to** buy her a surfboard that I saw last week.

This decision has already been planned.

